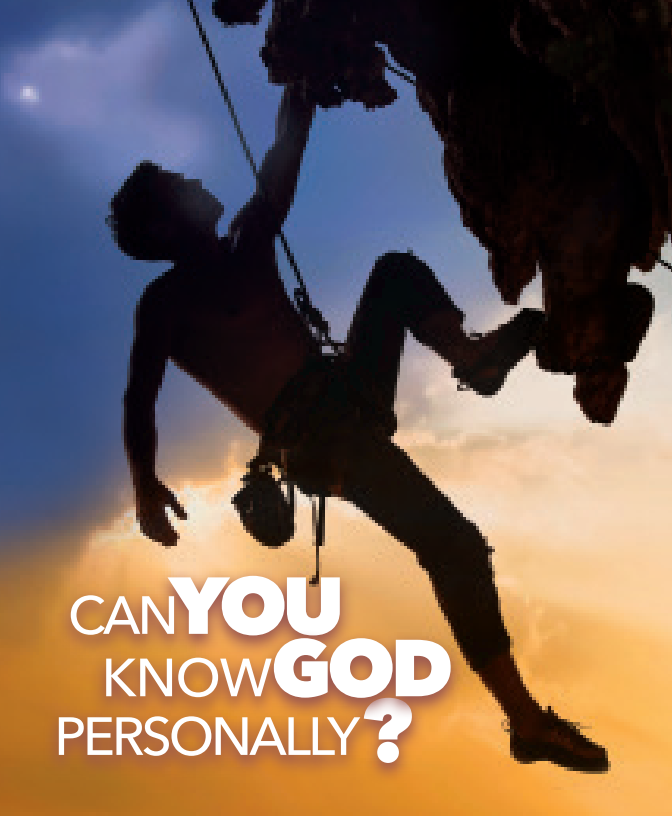


A silhouette of a person rappelling down a rope against a sunset sky. The person is shirtless, wearing a harness and a helmet, and is positioned diagonally across the frame. The background is a bright orange and yellow sunset sky with some clouds. The text "CAN YOU KNOW GOD PERSONALLY?" is overlaid in white, bold, sans-serif font at the bottom left.

CAN **YOU**
KNOW **GOD**
PERSONALLY?

Are you looking for success, for life purpose and direction, for love and acceptance, for security and peace? Do you want to experience forgiveness not based on your performance?

If we do not have a strong life purpose and direction, a tested and reliable life foundation, a sense of being loved and accepted for who we are, this creates in us a deep heart longing.

Sometimes we get a glimpse of this longing when we see some amazing things in the world around us. Maybe we see a giant glacier breaking off into the ocean, or a powerful crashing waterfall, or a breathtaking sunset, or we hold a newborn baby and something deep in us is awakened.

When a heart longing is awakened in us, what is that longing expressing? British author C. S. Lewis explained a heart longing this way:

It is sometimes felt as a longing for a far off country, but not a particular earthly land which we can identify....It may seem as a longing for a someone or even a something. But the majority of the people who experience it are not conscious of what or who the longed for objective may be. Indeed, the longing is of such profundity and intensity that the subject may immediately be only aware of the emotion itself and not cognizant that there is a something longed for.

[BY LEWIS, C.S. (1935). *The Pilgrims' Regress*, Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co]

How would you describe your heart longing? Do you picture anything in your mind? Does any particular place or person enter your thoughts?

Many people choose God to be their purpose and direction, their life foundation. God meets their heart longing.

The famous French physicist Blaise Pascal said there is one solution that will meet a person's heart longing. Only one thing matches, facet for facet, everything we need to meet our "heart longing and be our purpose, direction and life foundation". One person summarized Pascal's thoughts on how our heart longing is met in this way,

There is a God-shaped vacuum in the heart of every person that can't be filled by any created thing, but only by God the Creator made known through Jesus Christ.

(Bright, W.R....)

"Jesus is the most remarkable and fascinating person in history. He has inspired more hope, taught more compassion, and shown more love than any other man who has ever lived."

Bill Bright, businessman,
global Christian leader



ONE PERSON'S SEARCH

Have you ever known you should do something but just couldn't get yourself to do it, and then felt guilty because you didn't do it?

That was me as a student at Rice University. I was a smart, but ineffective slacker, unable or unwilling to change myself. I also had problems with my girlfriend. I knew there needed to be changes, but I just couldn't get there, I couldn't focus. I finally decided that I was making a mess of my life, and I began to search for answers.

Growing up, I went to church, but what I learned there about God wasn't helping me much. In college I saw a big difference between knowing about God and actually knowing Him. I thought being a Christian meant acting in a certain way, like being nice to everyone. When I tried, I could smile and be nice, but when not trying, I was not friendly or caring.

While searching for answers, a friend told me that Jesus could give me the peace and purpose I was looking for. He said Jesus would forgive me for my unkindness, and the other things I did that came from not trusting God.

I resisted accepting this. First, I didn't want to stop doing things that I enjoyed, that I thought wouldn't pass God's approval. Second, it scared me to think of someone else telling me what to do. What if I didn't like God's plan for me? As I looked at Jesus's life I had the confidence that He

would forgive me, and give me the peace and purpose I was seeking, so I decided to give Him a chance.

Soon I noticed changes. I still wrestled with studies, but a sense of peace was there, and I was able to focus and work hard (I even made the Dean's list.) I no longer had to try to be friendly and kind - I was becoming that way on the inside.

Now married with 3 children, I am an Executive Coach for a large multi-national company. Family health issues, financial decisions, and balancing work and home are a few of my challenges. When facing them I sometimes lose focus, but as I choose to trust God, purpose and peace return and I have His power to face life's challenges.

This booklet explains how you can know God for yourself and experience His peace and purpose. He can and will meet the longing of your heart. ■

God wants to have a personal relationship with you. He wants to give you forgiveness, unconditional love and life purpose.

One of the barriers that prevents us from knowing God personally is our lack of knowledge of who God is and what He has done for us.

The following points summarize what you read in the previous account of how one man met God. These points will help you discover more about God and what He has done for you. They explain how you can experience purpose, forgiveness, peace and the reality of having a relationship with God.

1 GOD LOVES YOU UNCONDITIONALLY AND CREATED YOU TO KNOW HIM PERSONALLY. HE WANTS TO MEET YOUR HEART LONGING AND BE YOUR PURPOSE AND LIFE FOUNDATION.

GOD'S LOVE

“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.” (John 3:16)*

GOD'S PLAN

“And this is eternal life, that they know you, the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom you have sent.” (John 17:3)

“I came that they may have life, and have it abundantly.” (John 10:10)

What prevents us from knowing God personally?

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2 WHEN PEOPLE ARE INDIFFERENT TO GOD AND SEPARATED FROM HIM, THEY CANNOT KNOW HIM PERSONALLY AND EXPERIENCE HIS LOVE.

PEOPLE'S INDIFFERENCE TO GOD IS AN EVIDENCE OF SIN

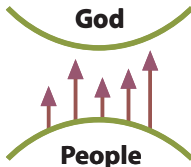
“For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:23)

We were created to experience God's love and have a relationship with Him, but because of our stubborn self-will, we chose to go our own independent way and fellowship with God was broken. This self-will, characterized by a heart attitude of active rebellion or passive indifference, is an evidence of what the Bible calls sin. The specific actions we often think of as sin, such as lying, stealing or murder, are an evidence of this heart attitude.

PEOPLE ARE SEPARATED

“For the wages of sin is death...
[separation from God].”

(Romans 6:23)



This diagram illustrates there is a great separation between us and God because we are imperfect and God is holy and perfect.

The arrows illustrate that when we try to bridge the gap and reach God by our own efforts we inevitably fail.



The third point explains the only way to bridge the separation between us and God...

3 GOD SENT JESUS CHRIST AS THE ONLY PROVISION FOR OUR SIN AND INDIFFERENCE TO HIM. THROUGH HIM ALONE YOU CAN KNOW GOD AND EXPERIENCE HIS LOVE.

HE DIED IN OUR PLACE

“...but God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” (Romans 5:8)

HE ROSE FROM THE DEAD

“Christ died for our sins...he was buried...he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures...he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve. Then he appeared to more than five hundred....” (1 Corinthians 15:3–6)

HE LOVED AND GAVE

“God showed how much he loved us by sending his one and only Son into the world so that we might have eternal life through him. This is real love—not that we loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as a sacrifice to take away our sins.”

(1 John 4:9-10, NLT)

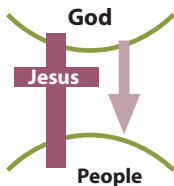
HE DID NOT COME TO CONDEMN, BUT TO SAVE

“For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but in order that the world might be saved through

Suppose you were walking across a bridge over a roaring river and you slipped and fell into the rushing river. Jesus wouldn't stand on the bridge yelling to you, "Why did you do such an irresponsible thing like that and fall into the river? Don't you know better?" No. Jesus would quickly jump into the river to save you because he loves you so much. Most people don't realize that they are in the roaring river and Jesus has jumped in to save them. Will we fight him off or will we let him put his arms of love around us and save us?

HE IS THE ONLY WAY TO GOD

"Jesus said to him, 'I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father, except through Me.'" (John 14:6)



This diagram illustrates that God bridged the separation between Himself and us by sending His Son, Jesus Christ to die on the cross in our place to pay the penalty for our sins. **It is not enough just to know these truths...**

4 WE MUST INDIVIDUALLY ACCEPT JESUS CHRIST AS SAVIOR* AND LORD, THEN WE CAN HAVE A PERSONAL RELATIONSHIP WITH GOD AND HE BECOMES OUR PURPOSE AND LIFE FOUNDATION.

WE MUST ACCEPT CHRIST

“But to all who did receive him, who believed in his name, he gave the right to become children of God...”
(John 1:12)

WE ACCEPT CHRIST THROUGH FAITH

“For by grace* you have been saved through faith*. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.” (Ephesians 2:8, 9)

* Grace is something unearned. Faith is placing your trust in something or someone. Savior is what Jesus is called because He saved us from the penalty of our sin.

WHEN WE ACCEPT CHRIST, WE EXPERIENCE A NEW BIRTH

(John 3:1-8, Jesus telling a religious leader about the new birth)

WE ACCEPT CHRIST BY PERSONAL INVITATION

[Christ is speaking] “Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me.”
(Revelation 3:20)

Receiving or accepting Christ involves turning to God from self and trusting Christ to come into your life to forgive your sins and help you become all He created you to be. Just to agree intellectually that Jesus Christ is the Son of God and that He died on the cross for your sins is not enough. Nor is it enough to have an emotional experience. You accept Jesus Christ by faith, as an act of your will.

These two circles represent two kinds of lives:

Self-Directed Life

S – Self is on the throne.

† – Christ is outside the life.

- – Interests are directed by self often resulting in discord and frustration.



Christ-Directed Life

† – Christ is in the life and on the throne.

S – Self is yielding to Christ.

- – Interests are directed by Christ resulting in harmony with God's plan.



Which circle best represents your life?

Which circle would you like to have represent your life?

The following explains how you can accept Christ...

YOU CAN ACCEPT CHRIST RIGHT NOW BY FAITH THROUGH PRAYER

(Prayer is talking with God)

God knows your heart and is not so concerned with your words as He is with the attitude of your heart.

The following is a suggested prayer:

*Lord Jesus, I want to know You personally.
Thank You for dying on the cross for my sins.
I open the door of my life and accept You
as my Savior and Lord. Thank You for forgiving
my sins and giving me eternal life. Take control
of the throne of my life. Make me the person
You created and designed me to be.*

Does this prayer express the desire of your heart?

If it does, you can pray this prayer right now and Jesus Christ will come into your life as He promised.

HOW TO KNOW THAT CHRIST IS IN YOUR LIFE AND THAT GOD IS NOW YOUR LIFE FOUNDATION

Did you invite Christ into your life? According to His promise in Revelation 3:20 (see page 14), where is Christ right now in relation to you? Christ said that He would come into your life. Would He mislead you? On what authority do you know that God has answered your prayer? (The trustworthiness of God Himself and His Word, as found in the Bible.)

THE BIBLE PROMISES ETERNAL LIFE TO ALL WHO RECEIVE CHRIST

“And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life. I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life.” (1 John 5:11–13)

Thank God often that Christ is in your life and that He will never leave you (Hebrews 13:5). You can know on the basis of His promise that Christ lives in you and that you have eternal life from the very moment you invite Him in. He will not deceive you.

DO NOT DEPEND ON FEELINGS

You might have expectations about how you should feel after placing your trust in Christ. While feelings are important they are unreliable indicators of your sincerity or the trustworthiness of God's promise. Our feelings change easily, but God's Word and His character remain constant. This illustration shows the relationship between fact (God and his Word), faith (our trust in God and his Word) and our feelings.



FACT - This chair is strong enough to support you.

FAITH - You believe this chair will support you, so you sit in it.

FEELING - No matter how you feel about sitting in the chair, it will continue to support you.

The promise of God's Word, the Bible, not our feelings is our authority. As a Christian (follower of Christ) you can now live by faith/trust in the trustworthiness of God Himself and His Word.

**NOW THAT YOU HAVE BEGUN A PERSONAL
RELATIONSHIP WITH CHRIST AND HAVE GOD
AS YOUR PURPOSE AND LIFE FOUNDATION MANY
SIGNIFICANT THINGS ARE YOURS**

The moment you received Christ by faith, as an act of your will, many things happened, including the following:

- Christ came into your life. (Rev. 3:20 and Col. 1:27)
- Your sins were forgiven. (Colossians 1:14)
- You became a child of God. (John 1:12)
- You received eternal life. (John 5:24)
- You began the great adventure for which God created you. (John 10:10; 2 Cor. 5:17; and 1 Thess. 5:18)
- You now have God as your solid life foundation on which to base your life direction and decisions.

Can you think of anything more wonderful that could happen to you than entering into a personal relationship with Jesus Christ? Would you like to thank God in prayer right now for what He has done for you? Prayer is talking with God. By thanking God, you demonstrate your faith.

To enjoy your new relationship with God...

SUGGESTIONS FOR ENJOYING GOD AND GROWING IN YOUR RELATIONSHIP WITH HIM

Spiritual enjoyment and growth results from trusting Jesus Christ. "...The righteous shall live by faith." (Gal. 3:11) A life of faith will enable you to know God better and trust Him more with every detail of your life.

- You will know God better as you talk to him daily about what is on your heart. (This is called prayer.)
(John 15:7)

"...Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus." (Philippians 4:6-7)

- You will learn more about God and how you can follow him by reading God's Word / the Bible as much as you can. (Daily is most helpful.) (Acts 7:11)
Begin with the Book of John.

- You can know God better and follow Him as you do what He asks you to do.

“He loves you and has your best in mind.” (John 14:21 LB)

- You will know God better by letting others see Christ by your life and words so they also can experience His great love for them. (Matthew 4:19; John 15:8)
- You will know God better as you trust Him for every detail of your life. “...casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.” (1 Peter 5:7)
- You will have the power to know God better as you allow the Holy Spirit to control and empower your daily life. He will empower every aspect of your life. (Gal. 5:16, 17; Acts 1:8)



FELLOWSHIP IN A GOOD CHURCH

God's Word encourages us, "Let's see how inventive we can be in encouraging love and helping out, not avoiding worshipping together...." (Hebrews 10:25 THE MESSAGE)

Several logs burn brightly together, but put one aside and its fire goes out. So it is with your relationship with other Christians. To not be alone in following Christ, you will want to go to a church. A church is where followers of Christ (Christians) get together to learn about Christ, to honor Him and to spend time with other followers.

If you do not belong to a church, take the initiative. Call the pastor of a nearby church where Christ and God's Word are honored. Start this week and make plans to attend regularly. 

Special resources are available for christian growth

If you have further questions about knowing Christ personally, visit: everyperson.com and see the life-coaching resources of *QUEST™* and *SOARING™* and *YouGo!™* at: thesignificanceproject.org

To know more about growing as a Christian, visit: startingwithgod.com and see the life-coaching courses, *Man of Impact™* and *The Significant Woman™* at: thesignificanceproject.org

To download *Jesus®* (a video about the life of jesus) or *Magdalena®* (a video that shows how jesus helped women) on your computer, or as a free app on your phone, visit: jesusfilm.org

To order more of these booklets or other Christian resources visit: crustore.org
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*Bright, W.R. (1968) *Jesus and the Intellectual*, Bright Media Foundation (paraphrase of a quote from page 75, Pascal, B. [1966]. *Pensées*. Penguin Books.)

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